

## Changing the Way We Do Business: A Job Development Case Study Improving Staff Skills and Paid Job Outcomes for Students with Disabilities

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The opportunity to hold a paid job while in high school helps students prepare for productive employment after high school (Cameto, NLTS2). In fact, the most prominent factors known to be associated with successful post-school outcomes are paid and unpaid work experiences during the last years of secondary school (Colley & Jamison, 1998; Luecking, 2009; Luecking & Fabian, 2001). The bottom line? Paid employment experience during secondary school is a predictor of post-school success.

This fact is relevant for special education teachers, transition specialists, and staff of postsecondary education transition programs on college campuses working with transitioning youth with intellectual disabilities. These professionals can and should be in position to help students secure jobs while they are still in school, as part of their academic program. This includes

- the professionals' ability to identify job opportunities and competency requirements and to develop worksites and work experience programs for transitioning students with disabilities (Blalock et al., 2003)
- the demonstrated knowledge of marketing, job development, and on-the-job training and supports (APSE, 2010)
- staff dedicated to job development, with appropriate skills, with the time and flexibility in their schedules to commit to job development activities (Grigal & Dwyre, 2010)

While special education teachers, transition coordinators, and postsecondary program staff have a wealth of skills, many lack the knowledge and strategies to assist students in finding and maintaining jobs. This brief describes a project that sought to find effective and low-cost ways to improve secondary and postsecondary professionals' job development skills.

### TRAINING AND FIELDWORK INTERVENTION

In one Maryland school district, TransCen, Inc. provided a job development training and fieldwork intervention to transition specialists, including staff of a postsecondary education transition program at a community college, from 2009–2011. This intervention led to new service strategies, new structures within the Transition Department, and new business partnering techniques—all resulting in partnerships with more local businesses and a significant increase in paid jobs for their students.

Prior to the intervention, the Harford County Public Schools (HCPS) transition specialists had developed very few paid jobs for their students with disabilities, and admitted that paid work for this population had not been a high priority. At the administration's request, the Transition Department was shifting its priorities toward paid employment outcomes. During the pre-intervention assessment, transition staff listed several areas in which they lacked the knowledge they needed to find their students paid jobs:

- Conducting cold calls
- Participating in general job development activities
- Approaching employers (when they had no idea how to create a marketing plan.) Working to find jobs within today's difficult economic conditions
- Countering the low expectations of businesses and parents about what students are capable of doing
- Addressing the desire of businesses that all their employees be cross-trained to do every task
- Addressing the general reluctance of businesses to work with people with disabilities
- Equipping students with the motivation and self-knowledge required for the job search

## THE INTERVENTION

In this section, we describe the procedures used to provide quarterly staff development and technical assistance over the course of the two-year intervention. Transition Specialists participated in four face-to-face training sessions covering all aspects of the job development process and 14 intensive fieldwork sessions to practice the skills and strategies presented in the training sessions.

### In-Person Skill Training

The four face-to-face training sessions were on the following topics:

| Session   | Session Title                                                                                                                             | Material Covered                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Session 1 | Developing Work Experiences and Jobs for Youth with Disabilities: The Art of Possibility, The Joy of Discovery, The Reward of Opportunity | Overview of customized employment, strategies for discovery and assessment, how to develop a Positive Personal Profile, how to get a foot in the door of employers, how to market students, how to negotiate customized positions, and ideas for helping students keep jobs. |
| Session 2 | Customized Employment: Job Coaching and Follow-Along                                                                                      | Overview of workplace support strategies to help students maintain jobs. In addition, facilitated discussion allowed staff to identify issues and challenges they had faced and share successful experiences and new strategies.                                             |
| Session 3 | HCPS: Where We Are One Year Later                                                                                                         | Focus group to review challenges, positive changes, future steps, and new skills.                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Session 4 | Job Development in Harford County – The Next Steps                                                                                        | Culmination training reviewing the past two years of progress, discussing a county-wide discovery intervention, and discussing how to maintain the momentum and the business relationships developed through this process.                                                   |

### Fieldwork

Following the initial training session and throughout the intervention, fieldwork assignments were initiated. Fourteen fieldwork sessions each involved informational interviews or company tours with 3-4 businesses per field session day. The Transition Specialists who participated used a script developed from the initial training, pairing one or two staff with a TransCen trainer. The trainer typically demonstrated an informational interview with an employer, allowed each transition specialist to take the lead on other interviews, and spent time afterward debriefing. From these connections, transition specialists were expected to follow up with employer contacts and negotiate hires for students.

## RESULTS: QUALITATIVE

### Skill Development

A post-assessment of the same staff at the end of the training and fieldwork intervention revealed that staff felt they do a much better job of:

- Getting students to think about their future
- Matching student interests and skills to job opportunities
- Helping students get paid jobs while they are still in school
- Approaching businesses with the new strategies modeled
- Approaching job development in a more professional and business-centered manner, focusing more on student capabilities and using that focus to assist in the job development process
- Gathering more meaningful information about students that can be used to market them effectively to businesses
- Focusing more on student needs and interests, leading to more focused approaches to businesses and resulting in more positive responses
- Using Community Based Instruction (CBI) field trips more for career exploration and assessment
- Raising expectations of students and families to involve them more in the process

In the Future Link Postsecondary Education program at Harford County Community College, the transition specialists also reported connecting college courses and experiences to students' career plans and interests. This allowed them to create more opportunities for students on and off campus, connecting school to the real world, and making students more marketable to businesses.

## Systems Change

In order to support more successful job development practices, the district administration made changes to the structure of some services within the transition department:

- There is now one trained transition specialist assigned to job-develop for the Future Link program, HCPS's Postsecondary Education Transition Program for students with intellectual disabilities, based at Harford Community College.
- The school district has incorporated a version of the Positive Personal Profile tool for discovery and assessment into the general transition interview for all special education students.
- Transition specialists will now be required to report the number of students with paid work experiences.

## RESULTS: QUANTITATIVE

### Increased paid jobs acquired by students

When the intervention began, the majority of students who the transition specialists supported were in volunteer work experience sites. The district did not have any system for tracking paid vs. unpaid work. During informal discussion, the transition specialists reported that they knew of three students in paid work, two of whom acquired those jobs on their own after school and on weekends. During the 2011–2012 school year, as documented in new system-wide tracking forms in January 2012 that was developed in part to capture the results of this intervention and the new focus on paid employment, there were 24 students in paid jobs, 11 of whom were students in the Future Link Postsecondary Education Transition program at Harford Community College.

### Increased business partnerships

From November 2009 to January 2012, the transition specialists reported developing business relationships with 66 new local companies in a variety of industries, including the Boys & Girls Club, the Maritime Museum, several car dealerships, an auto auction house, the local Chamber of Commerce, a regional label printing and production house, a custom spices and seasonings manufacturer, and a large regional pharmacy distribution center. Some of these relationships have led to training and education experiences for students, work tryouts, industry tours, and assessment sites, in addition to paid jobs.

## DISCUSSION

For students with intellectual disabilities, there are several barriers to getting paid jobs. One major barrier is lack of training on the part of the professionals tasked with helping these students get jobs, in combination with system structures that are not conducive to effective job development. For transition programs to have successful outcomes for their students, paid employment must be the goal and job development staff must be trained in effective strategies. In addition, staff must be given the time and flexibility to use those strategies.

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**Given the appropriate knowledge, tools, and strategies—and the opportunity to practice those skills through modeled fieldwork—transition professionals can learn to partner with businesses, make good job matches, and provide meaningful follow-along support that can significantly improve the paid employment outcomes of the students they serve.**

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The intervention provided to this Maryland school system resulted in structural changes and trained staff, which led to a nearly 700% increase in paid jobs within two school years and the development of 66 new local business relationships. As evidenced in Harford County Public Schools, this intervention model improves employment outcomes in both secondary and postsecondary education transition programs. Given the appropriate knowledge, tools, and strategies—and the opportunity to practice those skills through modeled fieldwork—transition professionals can learn to partner with businesses, make good job matches, and provide meaningful follow-along support that can significantly improve the paid employment outcomes of the students they serve.

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## INSIGHT, Issue No. 18, 2013

INSIGHT is a publication of Think College, a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston, funded by grants from the Administration on Developmental Disabilities (CFDA# 93-632, Grant No. 90DD0659), and the Office of Postsecondary Education (Grant No. P407B100002). The opinions contained in this document are those of the grantee and do not necessarily reflect those of the funders.

Recommended citation for this brief: Dwyre, A., & Deschamps, A. (2013). *Changing the Way We Do Business: A Job Development Case Study. Improving Staff Skills and Paid Job Outcomes for Students with Disabilities*. Think College. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

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